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DHS confirms Mexican citizen's death in ICE custody in Georgia

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The Department of Homeland Security confirmed the death of a Mexican citizen in an immigration detention facility this week in Georgia, as Mexican authorities sought details surrounding the circumstances of the incident.

On Wednesday, Heber Sanchez Domínguez, a 34-year-old Mexican citizen, died while in U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement custody at the Robert A. Deyton Detention Center in Clayton County, south of Atlanta, DHS said in a statement Friday. The cause of death is currently under investigation.

Sanchez was in ICE custody for six days and was awaiting a hearing when he was discovered "hanging by the neck and unresponsive in his sleeping quarters" at about 2:05 a.m. local time, DHS said. Medical staff immediately attempted lifesaving measures and then transported him to a hospital, where he was pronounced dead about one hour later.

ICE said it first encountered Sanchez on Jan. 7 after he was arrested for driving without a license, DHS said. Two days later, on Jan. 9, ICE filed a notice requiring Sanchez to appear before an immigration judge.

DHS said Sanchez entered the U.S. illegally on Dec. 22, 2023, at or near Nogales, Arizona. Border Patrol agents arrested him that same day and issued him a notice to

appear. He was later released without bond.

After his Jan. 7 arrest, ICE transferred Sanchez to the Robert A. Deyton Detention Center as he awaited removal proceedings. Medical staff conducted an intake evaluation and reported no signs of distress at the time.

On Thursday, Mexico's consulate in Atlanta said it was "closely monitoring" the death of a Mexican citizen Wednesday at the Robert A. Deyton Detention Facility and was maintaining "permanent communication" with the ICE field office in Atlanta.

Mexican officials requested "that the circumstances of the incident be clarified," the consulate said, adding that it was "collaborating on the necessary procedures to ensure that the investigation is conducted promptly and transparently."

The consulate said it planned to return the remains to Mexico as soon as possible.

ICE has been at the forefront of President Trump's mass deportation campaign.

About 73,000 people facing deportation were being held by ICE as of Thursday, according to internal DHS data obtained by CBS News. This marks the first time in the deportation agency's 23-year history that the number of ICE detainees has surpassed the 70,000 mark.

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Last year, 2025, was the deadliest year for ICE detainees in two decades, with at least 30 people dying in detention centers. At least four people have died in ICE detention so far this year, according to agency data.

The agency has come under intense public scrutiny in recent days following the [fatal shooting of 37-year-old Renee Good](#) by an immigration officer in Minneapolis on Jan. 7, sparking protests across the U.S.

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